

Handout for Draft One

As you work on your draft, ask yourself if any of your paragraphs are either just listing cases or making general claims, rather than *both*. Ask yourself:

In this paragraph, can I *provide more evidence*?

What specific instances can you present to defend a larger insight?

In this paragraph, can I *provide more meaning*?

What broad insight applies to many examples/pieces of evidence?

Both *gathering more evidence* and *making broader points* will open up new pathways for more fully developing your essay question.

As you work on your draft, it may also be helpful to keep in mind the main ‘jobs,’ or specialized purposes, that you might assign to individual paragraphs

As you write your drafts, first:

1). Make a thesis claim.

As you begin your draft, feel free to simply write down thesis sentences that describe your initial plan for your paper, instead of composing a full introductory paragraph. Often, it works best to complete the introductory paragraph *after* you’ve completed the rest of your draft. As you write an initial thesis or adjust your thesis, keep in mind that the thesis needs to be general enough to give you space to explore in your essay and specific enough to help you stick to thinking about material that tightly relates.

Next, be sure to compose sections of your paper that use a high density of ‘quote sandwiches’ to:

A). Tell us what happened or is currently happening (in history).

Providing a context of historical events that help explain your problem will be an important part of your papers. Each of your sources likely refers to or a context of events. Tell us about an event or sequence of events that’s important for understanding the sources of your issue.

B). Identify (possible, probable, or certain) causes.

Ultimately, your primary goal for this paper is to identify causes of your problem. Thinking about each of our problems requires attention to complex conditions and events, for which there is no *single* cause. Rather than single-mindedly asserting any one cause, then, we need to *consider* the possible, probable, or certain *contributing* causes for the issues we are facing. Help us think through one of multiple of what you see as main contributing causes that help to explain the problem that’s central to your paper, or one of its sub-problems. Are there facts that support your identification of a cause? Does the cause help explain the issue in some

contexts and not others? And, if so, what questions for further investigation and reflection does your search for root causes raise?

C). Describe the impacts.

What does the problem look or feel like for those who are most affected? In order to help your readers appreciate the *impact* of the problem, can you describe important aspects of the *experiences* at stake?

Plan to return to your introductory paragraph after you've completed the rest of the draft, so that you can initially introduce major causes and impacts there.

Toward these goals of your paper, you will need to compose paragraphs that may seem to simply:

l). Tell us what the writer says (summarize).

Identify the major point(s) from the source that matter for your argument.

Directly quote from the source when possible.

Paraphrase or 'translate' in order to clarify the writer's meaning.

Illustrate the relevant point(s) from the source.

Ask yourself if describing the writer's style (how they say something, in addition to what they say) might contribute to the insights you can offer about the source.

&). Offer your interpretation of what the writer says.

Make sure to present reasons for your way of thinking about what the writer says. In addition to developing claims about how the source's points matter to your argument, you may occasionally want to express approval or disapproval of something the writer says. If and when you do so, be sure to carefully explain specific reasons for your approval or disapproval.

#). Compare and contrast aspects of two (or more) sources.

How are the claims that the writers make like one another and how are they unlike one another?

You will likely need to consider points of comparison one-by-one in multiple paragraphs.

Be sure to illustrate/provide examples that explain the points in the sources you are comparing and your claims about those points.

What different ways of thinking about the problem emerge through your comparison? With what different social and historical contexts are the readings engaging? What general insights emerge through seeing what multiple sources share?

Plan to return to your introductory paragraph after you've completed the rest of the draft, so that you can initially introduce points of comparison there.

Finally, be sure to:

8). Write a conclusion paragraph that emphasizes why your analysis/argument matters.